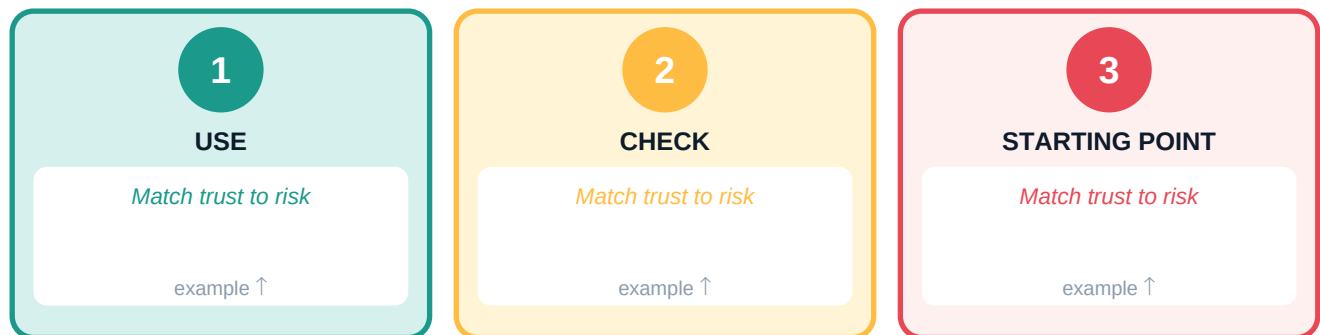


CHAPTER 22

Calibrating Trust



TRUST AS A CALIBRATION PROBLEM The wrong response to AI's failure modes is distrust of everything AI produces. The right response is calibrated trust: knowing which outputs to use confidently, which to verify before using, and which to treat as starting points only.

Calibration means your level of trust is proportionate to the actual risk profile of the output. A person who trusts everything AI produces equally, the sentence structure and the legal claim alike, will eventually rely on something they should have checked. A person who trusts nothing AI produces is throwing away most of the tool's value for no good reason.

THE TRUST CALIBRATION MATRIX Two dimensions determine how much trust is appropriate:

Stakes, What happens if this output is wrong?

High stakes: wrong output causes significant professional, financial, legal, or personal harm

Medium stakes: wrong output causes embarrassment, rework, or moderate professional consequences

Low stakes: wrong output is caught before any harm, or the consequences are easily reversible

Verifiability, How easily can you check this?

Easy: you can verify against a source you have access to in minutes

Moderate: verification requires more effort, finding sources, specialist input, research

Hard: verification requires expertise or information you don't have easy access to

Use these two dimensions to calibrate your verification investment:



STAKES \ EASY TO VERIFY **MODERATE** **HARD TO VERIFY**

High stakes Verify and Verify carefully, Do not rely on AI alone, document seek expert use as one input among input several

Medium stakes Verify key Spot-check Flag uncertainty; claims critical elements present as AI-assisted

Low stakes Read Use with Use cautiously; review if critically awareness consequences grow

BUILDING A PERSONAL TRUST CALIBRATION Over time, you will build a sense of where AI performs reliably for your specific use cases and where it consistently needs correction.

This is worth tracking, at least informally. When you notice a consistent failure pattern, AI always overestimates timelines in project plans; AI never quite captures your organisation's formal register; AI gets financial calculations wrong, note it. That pattern becomes a standing verification rule in your practice.

When you notice consistent strengths, AI always produces excellent first-draft email structures; AI is consistently right about the logical order of a presentation; AI's summarisation of meeting notes is almost always accurate, you can extend trust in those areas and invest verification effort where it's most needed.

Calibration is personal and task-specific. It improves with experience.

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REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE David has now used AI consistently for six months across his consultancy work. He has noticed:

Reliable: Drafting client emails (he rarely changes more than a sentence). Structuring proposals. Summarising meeting notes from his own bullet-point notes (not from transcripts). Producing presentation outlines.

Needs checking: Any output that contains specific market data or statistics. Recommendations that require knowing something about a client he may not have fully briefed. Legal or regulatory claims about anything jurisdiction- specific.

Use as starting point only: Any financial projections or estimates. Technical specifications for systems he isn't deeply expert in. Anything where the quality of the output depends heavily on current information he hasn't provided.

His verification practice is proportionate: high effort where he knows errors are likely; lighter touch where AI is consistently reliable. He doesn't spend time verifying email structure and doesn't use AI financial projections without checking every number.

COMMUNICATING AI-ASSISTED WORK In professional contexts, it is worth having a clear internal policy on how you represent AI-assisted work:

What to disclose: When AI has generated factual claims, analysis, or recommendations that appear in work presented to clients, stakeholders, or colleagues, it is good practice to note that AI tools were used in preparation and that claims have been verified. This is both honest and a natural quality signal.



PART VI - THE AI USER'S PLAYBOOK

What you remain responsible for: AI is a tool. You are accountable for the work. If an AI-generated figure in a report is wrong, "AI produced it" is not a professional defence. Your review process, your verification standard, and your decision to include it are yours.

The credibility calculation: In most professional contexts, "I used AI to help draft this and then carefully verified it" is now a normal and credible statement. "I relied on AI without checking" is not. The trust question is whether your process is sound, not whether AI was involved.

WATCH OUT TRUST MISCALIBRATION CAN GO IN BOTH DIRECTIONS. OVER-TRUSTING AI PRODUCES ERRORS THAT DAMAGE

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